



KASHIGO

2026 EDITION

Kashi

Unveiled

The Spiritual Traveller's
Guide to Varanasi

VAIBHAV UPADHYAY

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VAIBHAV UPADHYAY • KASHIGO

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Before You Begin

I was born in Varanasi. I learned to swim in the Ganga before I learned to ride a bicycle, I learned the names of the ghats before I learned the names of the planets, and I have stood on the steps at sunrise more mornings than I can count. And still, every time I bring a friend from abroad to the river for the first time, I watch their face and I see the city again as if I had never seen it.

That is what this book is for.

There are many guides that will tell you where to go in Varanasi. Fewer will tell you *why* the place matters, why a grandmother from Tamil Nadu has saved for thirty years to bathe at one particular ghat, why a family will carry a body through the lanes chanting the name of Rama, why a priest swings a flame in slow circles over a dark river every single evening without fail. Without the meaning, Varanasi can feel like noise, smoke and crowds. With the meaning, the same scene becomes one of the most moving things you will ever witness.

This book is written for the traveller who wants to understand. Perhaps you practise yoga and want to see the land where many of its ideas took shape. Perhaps you are a seeker of no particular tradition, drawn by something you cannot quite name. Perhaps you are the child of Indian parents, raised in London or New Jersey or Sydney, and you want to finally know what your grandmother meant when she spoke of "Kashi" in that soft, particular voice. Or perhaps you are simply curious, and a little nervous, and want to arrive prepared.

Whoever you are, welcome.

How this book is organised

The chapters move from the large to the small: the idea of Kashi, the river, death and liberation, then the living rituals, temples, Sarnath and festivals, and finally music, practice, food and everyday courtesy. A glossary at the end gathers the Sanskrit and Hindi words you will hear.

Throughout, you will find two kinds of boxed notes:

LOCAL TIP

Practical advice from someone who grew up here, the sort of thing a friend would whisper to you on the steps.

DID YOU KNOW?

A fact, story or detail that adds a little more depth to what you are seeing.

A note on belief and fact

Varanasi is a city where myth and history are braided together so tightly that locals rarely bother to separate them. In this book I try to be clear about which is which. When I say that Shiva is believed to whisper a

mantra into the ear of the dying, I am describing a belief held by millions of people, not a scientific claim. When I give a date for a temple's construction, I have tried to use the best-supported date, and where historians disagree I say so.

I am a Hindu by birth and a son of this city, but this is not a book that asks you to believe anything. Varanasi has always been a place of many paths. The Buddha taught his first sermon a few kilometres away. Jain tradition honours Kashi as the birthplace of several Tirthankaras. Kabir, the weaver-poet who mocked empty ritual of every kind, lived and sang in these lanes. Muslim weavers have woven the city's famous silk for centuries, and the greatest shehnai player India has known played his music facing the Ganga. You are welcome here as you are.

A note on change

Varanasi changes faster than its ancient image suggests. Temple rules, timings, prices and access routes shift, sometimes from one season to the next. Where I give timings and rules, treat them as a careful starting point, and check locally or on official websites before you rely on them. I have marked the places where this matters most.

Now, take a breath. Let us walk down to the river.



CHAPTER 1

Why Kashi: The City of Light

The name that means light

The oldest name of this city is Kashi, and it comes from a Sanskrit root, *kash*, meaning "to shine." Kashi is the luminous one, the City of Light. In the traditional understanding, the light is not the sunlight on the river, beautiful as that is. It is the light of knowledge, the light of awareness, the light that, according to Hindu belief, dissolves the darkness of ignorance and frees the soul.

You will hear three names used almost interchangeably, and each carries its own flavour.

Kashi is the sacred name, the one used in scripture, in prayer, and by pilgrims. When an old man from a village says he is "going to Kashi," he is not making a tourist trip. He is going to the holiest place on earth.

Banaras (also spelled Benares) is the name of everyday life, of silk and paan and music and the particular sweetness of the local dialect. A "Banarasi" person is someone with a certain unhurried, witty, devotional, slightly mischievous attitude to life. When people speak of Banaras, they usually mean the city's culture, its *masti*, its flavour.

Varanasi is the official name, restored in 1956, and the most geographically precise. The city lies between two small rivers that flow into the Ganga: the **Varuna** to the north and the **Assi** to the south. Varuna plus Assi gives Varanasi. Today the Assi is a modest stream, much of it channelled, but Assi Ghat still marks the southern edge of the traditional riverfront, and the name is a map of the sacred city in a single word.

DID YOU KNOW?

Locals often use all three names in the same sentence without noticing. You might hear someone say, "Banaras ka paan, Kashi ke Vishwanath, aur Varanasi ka traffic" — Banaras for its paan, Kashi for its Lord Vishwanath, and Varanasi for its traffic. It is only half a joke.

Shiva's city

To understand Kashi you need to know one thing above all: in Hindu belief, this is the city of **Shiva**.

Shiva is one of the great deities of Hinduism, often described as the destroyer within the trinity of creation, preservation and dissolution. But "destroyer" is a misleading English word. Shiva dissolves what is false so that what is real can remain. He is the great ascetic meditating on the mountain, the dancer whose dance creates and ends the universe, the householder with his wife Parvati and their sons, the wild one smeared with ash from the cremation grounds. He is paradox embodied, and Kashi is his home.

Traditional texts, especially the *Kashi Khand* section of the Skanda Purana, describe the city in extraordinary terms. Kashi, they say, is not really built on the earth at all. It rests on the tip of Shiva's trident, held above the ordinary world, so that even when the universe dissolves at the end of a cosmic cycle, Kashi remains. It is called **Avimukta**, "never forsaken," because Shiva has promised never to leave it. It is also called **Anandavana**, the forest of bliss, and **Mahashmashana**, the great cremation ground.

That last name surprises many visitors. Why would the holiest city be named after a place where bodies are burned? The answer lies at the heart of what Kashi means.

Moksha: the promise of Kashi

Most Hindu traditions hold that the soul (*atman*) passes through a long chain of births and deaths, called **samsara**, shaped by the moral weight of its actions, called **karma**. The ultimate goal of spiritual life is not a better rebirth but release from the cycle altogether. This release is called **moksha**, liberation.

Moksha is usually understood to require lifetimes of effort, discipline, devotion and knowledge. But Kashi, according to belief, offers a kind of grace. Those who die within the sacred boundary of the city are said to receive moksha directly, because at the moment of death Shiva himself whispers into their ear the **Taraka mantra**, the "mantra of crossing over," which carries the soul across the ocean of rebirth.

This single belief shapes the entire city. It is why the elderly come here in their final years. It is why the cremation fires at Manikarnika never go out. It is why so many families carry the ashes of loved ones here from across India and the world. And it is why, for all its intensity, Varanasi feels to many visitors strangely calm about death. Here death is not hidden away behind hospital curtains. It is part of the city's daily rhythm, and in the local understanding, dying in Kashi is not a tragedy but a

blessing.

You do not need to share this belief to feel its weight. Sit for half an hour on the steps near the burning ghat, and you will find that the city has quietly asked you a question about your own life.

The oldest living city?

You will often read that Varanasi is "the oldest continuously inhabited city in the world." It is a lovely line, and it is worth handling carefully.

What we can say with confidence is this: Varanasi is one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities on earth. Kashi appears as a kingdom and a city in very early Indian literature, including Buddhist texts from the time of the Buddha, roughly 2,500 years ago, when it was already an important and wealthy centre. Archaeological excavations in the northern part of the city, at Rajghat near the Varuna, have found evidence of settlement going back well over two and a half thousand years, and some researchers argue for considerably earlier dates.

Other cities, such as Jericho, Damascus, Byblos and Aleppo, also lay claim to extraordinary continuity, and historians debate exactly how to define "continuous." So the honest phrasing is that Varanasi is *among* the oldest living cities in the world, and almost certainly the oldest that has remained a living centre of the same religious tradition for so long. That is remarkable enough.

When the American writer Mark Twain visited in 1896, he famously wrote that Benares seemed older than history and older than tradition. Standing in the lanes behind the ghats at dawn, among temples, cows, bells and old stone, it is hard to disagree.

LOCAL TIP

Do not try to "see" Varanasi in a single day. The city does not reveal itself on a schedule. Give it at least two full days, and if you can, three or four. The best moments here are unplanned: a sudden procession, a conversation with a boatman, a raga drifting from an upstairs window.

The shape of the sacred city

Traditionally, Kashi is not a single point but a sacred territory, mapped by pilgrimage routes that circle it at different distances. The largest is the **Panchakroshi Yatra**, a pilgrimage route of roughly 80 kilometres that encircles the holy zone, walked over five days by devotees who stop at dozens of shrines on the way. Within that circle lie smaller sacred circuits, and at the centre, the temple of Vishwanath, the Lord of the Universe.

For the visitor, the sacred city is easiest to understand as a line: the long crescent of **ghats**, stone steps leading down into the river, stretching for several kilometres along the western bank of the Ganga, from Assi in the south to the area near the Varuna in the north. Behind the ghats lies the dense old city, a maze of narrow lanes called **galis**, too narrow for cars, where temples hide in courtyards and whole neighbourhoods have barely changed in centuries.

There are traditionally said to be **84 ghats**, though the exact count depends on how you divide them. Some are bathing ghats, some are cremation ghats, some were built by kings and queens from across India who wanted a palace and a staircase on the holiest river in the holiest city. Every one has a story.

What Kashi asks of you

I have watched many visitors arrive in Varanasi with their defences up. The noise, the crowds, the touts, the cows, the smoke and the frank presence of death can be a lot. Some people leave after a day, shaken. Others stay a week and then cancel the rest of their trip because they cannot bear to leave.

The difference is rarely about comfort. It is about attention. Kashi rewards those who slow down, who sit, who watch, who ask questions with genuine curiosity, and who allow themselves to be moved without needing to understand everything at once.

My suggestion for your first morning is simple. Wake before dawn. Walk down to the river. Find a quiet step. Sit, and do nothing for twenty minutes. Watch the light come up over the far bank. Watch the first bathers step into the water and raise their cupped hands to the sun. Listen to the bells begin.

That is Kashi introducing itself. Everything else in this book is commentary.

DID YOU KNOW?

Because the ghats face east across the river, Varanasi's riverfront is one of the great sunrise stages of the world. The far eastern bank is left largely undeveloped, a wide sandbank that by long tradition has not been built upon, so the sun rises over open sand and water, just as it would have for pilgrims a thousand years ago.



CHAPTER 2

The Ganga: River, Mother, Goddess

More than a river

To most of the world, the Ganges is a river: about 2,500 kilometres long, rising in the Himalayas, flowing across the plains of northern India and emptying into the Bay of Bengal. To hundreds of millions of Hindus, she is **Ganga Ma**, Mother Ganga, a living goddess who flows from heaven to earth for the sake of humanity.

Notice the pronoun. In Varanasi, nobody calls the river "it." She is *she*. People greet her in the morning, bow to her when they step into her water, offer her flowers and flame, and speak to her in prayer the way you might speak to an old and much-loved mother. When you hear a pilgrim say "Ganga Maiya ki jai" ("Victory to Mother Ganga"), you are hearing an expression of love, not merely respect.

Ganga is depicted in Hindu art as a beautiful woman riding a **makara**, a mythical water creature somewhere between a crocodile and a dolphin, holding a water pot. Her water, **Gangajal**, is kept in sealed copper or brass vessels in homes across India and the diaspora, used for purification, for blessing new homes, and placed on the lips of the dying.

How the river came down from heaven

The best-known story of Ganga's descent, told in the Ramayana and in several Puranas, goes something like this.

Long ago there was a king named **Sagara**, who performed a great horse sacrifice to establish his sovereignty. Indra, king of the gods, jealous of Sagara's growing power, stole the sacrificial horse and hid it near the hermitage of the sage **Kapila**, who was deep in meditation. Sagara's sixty thousand sons searched the earth for the horse, found it beside the sage, and accused him of theft. Disturbed from his meditation, Kapila opened his eyes, and the fire of his gaze reduced all sixty thousand princes to ashes.

Their souls could not find peace. Only the waters of the heavenly river Ganga, it was said, could purify their ashes and release them.

Generations passed. Sagara's descendants tried and failed to bring Ganga to earth. Finally, his great-great-grandson **Bhagiratha** undertook years of intense austerity. Pleased, the goddess Ganga agreed to descend. But there was a problem: the force of her fall from heaven would shatter the earth.

So Bhagiratha prayed to Shiva. Shiva agreed to receive the river in his matted locks, breaking her fall. Ganga, proud of her power, thought she would sweep Shiva away, but he simply caught her in his hair and held her there, letting her out in gentle streams. Bhagiratha then led the river across the land, all the way to the place where the ashes of his ancestors lay, and her waters released their souls.

This is why Shiva is so often shown with a small stream of water springing from his hair, and why one of Ganga's names is **Bhagirathi**, "she who was brought by Bhagiratha." The headstream of the Ganga in the Himalayas is still called the Bhagirathi. And the phrase "Bhagirath prayatna," a Bhagiratha-like effort, is still used in Hindi for any heroic, persistent labour.

Notice the meaning of the story: the river comes down to free the dead. From its very origin, Ganga is bound up with liberation, ancestors and the release of souls. That is exactly what you will see happening on her banks in Varanasi.

DID YOU KNOW?

The festival of **Ganga Dussehra**, usually in May or June, celebrates the day Ganga is believed to have descended to earth. In Varanasi, the ghats fill with bathers and lamps, and it is one of the most joyful river festivals of the year.

Why Varanasi's Ganga is special

The Ganga is sacred along its entire length, but at Varanasi two geographical features make her even more significant in traditional eyes.

First, the river here **flows north**. Across most of the plains, the Ganga flows broadly east and south-east toward the sea. But at Varanasi she makes a great bend and, for a stretch, turns toward the north, back toward the Himalayas, her source and Shiva's mountain home. A north-flowing river is called **Uttaravahini** and is considered especially auspicious, as if the river is turning to look back at where she came from. Places where a sacred river flows north are treated as specially holy.

Second, the river forms a **crescent** here, a long gentle curve. The ghats follow the outer edge of this curve on the western bank. Locals compare it to the crescent moon that Shiva wears in his hair, so that the city itself is laid out like an ornament of the god. When you take a sunrise boat and

look back at the ghats, you can see the curve clearly, the whole city arranged along one sweeping arc of stone.

The combination of the crescent and the north-flowing current also has a practical effect. The western bank, on the outside of the bend, sits on a ridge of relatively high, firm ground, which is why the city and its ghats were built there. The eastern bank, on the inside of the curve, is low and sandy, gathers silt, and floods each monsoon, which is one practical reason it was left open.

Why people bathe

If you go to the ghats at dawn, you will see hundreds of people bathing. Some immerse themselves fully, three times, holding their noses. Some stand waist-deep and pour water over their heads from a brass pot. Some cup water in their hands and offer it to the rising sun while murmuring a mantra. Some simply touch the water and then touch their foreheads.

This act is called **Ganga snan**, bathing in the Ganga. In belief, it washes away not dirt but sin, the accumulated negative karma of this life and perhaps of past lives. Bathing in the Ganga at Varanasi, especially on auspicious days such as full moons, eclipses and festivals, is considered one of the most purifying acts a Hindu can perform.

There is also an offering to the sun called **Surya arghya**: the bather faces east, holds water in cupped hands or a small pot, and lets it fall in a stream while looking toward the sun. Others offer **tarpan**, water poured out for ancestors, often with sesame seeds and kusha grass, to nourish and honour the departed.

For many people, the bath is also simply the start of an ordinary day. Old men who have bathed at the same ghat every morning for sixty years will bathe, do their prayers, chat with friends, read the newspaper on the steps and walk home for breakfast. The sacred and the everyday are not separate here.

Should you bathe or drink?

This is one of the most common questions I am asked, and I will answer it honestly, as I would answer a friend.

The Ganga is spiritually revered, but physically, the water at Varanasi carries a significant load of untreated sewage and other pollution. Government monitoring has for years recorded faecal coliform bacteria levels that are well above safe limits for bathing, particularly near drains and in the dry season. There have been major clean-up efforts and things are improving in some respects, but the river is not safe to drink untreated, and bathing carries real risk of stomach, skin and eye infections for visitors whose bodies are not accustomed to it.

My advice:

- **Do not drink the water.** Not even a sip. Not even if someone offers it to you as a blessing.
- **Think carefully before bathing fully.** If you feel a strong spiritual pull to enter the river, do it with your eyes and mouth closed, avoid swallowing any water, keep it brief, choose an upstream ghat away from drains, and shower thoroughly afterwards. Avoid it entirely if you have any open cuts.
- **Touching the water is enough.** Many devout Hindus simply sprinkle a few drops on their head or touch the water and then their forehead. This is a complete and respectful gesture. No one will think less of you.
- **Monsoon is different.** From roughly July to September, the river swells dramatically, the current becomes strong, and the lower ghats disappear underwater. Do not enter the water at all in monsoon.

LOCAL TIP

If you want to take home Gangajal for a family member, buy a small sealed bottle from a shop in the lanes rather than filling one yourself. It is the same spiritual gesture without the hygiene problem, and it will survive the flight.

How to behave by the river

The Ganga is a temple without walls. A few simple courtesies will help you move with ease:

- **Remove your shoes** when you step down onto the lowest bathing platforms or into the water, and on any part of a ghat where you see others barefoot. The upper steps are generally fine in shoes.
- **Do not throw rubbish** into the river, ever. Plastic is a real problem here, and locals notice.
- **Do not photograph bathers closely**, especially women, without clear permission. People are performing a private religious act in a public place. A wide shot of the riverfront at dawn is fine; a zoom lens on a woman changing her sari is not.
- **Do not point your feet** at shrines, at people doing prayers, or at the river itself while you sit. Tuck them to the side.
- **Keep voices low** at dawn. The riverfront at sunrise is a place of prayer.
- **Swimming for fun** is not really done here as recreation by adults on the main ghats, and the current can be dangerous. Leave the swimming to the local boys who grew up in it.

The river at different hours

Meet the river at more than one hour. **Before dawn** she is grey and still, mist hanging low in winter, the only sounds the dip of oars and the first bells. **At sunrise** the light strikes the ghats full on and bathers raise

their hands to the sun. **At dusk** the city gathers again for the aarti, and lamps drift on the dark water. **Late at night**, after the crowds have gone, the ghats belong to the city once more: men talking on the steps, a distant chant, and the fires of Manikarnika glowing to the north.



CHAPTER 3

Death and Liberation: The Burning Ghats

The fire that never goes out

Walk north along the ghats from Dashashwamedh and, within ten or fifteen minutes, you will notice the air change. Smoke drifts across the steps. Stacks of firewood, taller than a man, rise along the bank. Boats unload logs. Then you hear it, a group of men walking quickly through the lanes, carrying a bamboo stretcher on their shoulders, chanting "*Ram naam satya hai*" — "the name of Rama is truth." On the stretcher lies a body wrapped in white or saffron or red cloth, decorated with marigolds.

You have arrived at **Manikarnika Ghat**, the great cremation ground of Kashi.

For many visitors, this is the place they are most curious about and most nervous to see. For locals, it is simply part of the city, as ordinary and as holy as the temple bells. I grew up a short walk from the river, and like

every Banarasi child I learned early that the smoke over Manikarnika was nothing to fear. It was, the elders told us, the smoke of people going home.

Why cremation, and why here?

In Hindu tradition, the body is understood as a temporary dwelling for the soul. At death, the soul departs, and the body is returned to the five elements from which it was made: earth, water, fire, air and space. Cremation is the means of that return. Fire, personified as the god **Agni**, is the messenger who carries offerings to the gods, and in the funeral rite the body itself becomes the final offering.

Cremation anywhere is considered proper. Cremation in Kashi, beside the Ganga, is considered the most blessed of all, because of the belief we met in Chapter 1: that death within Kashi brings moksha, liberation from rebirth. Families travel from all over India, sometimes hundreds of kilometres, to cremate their dead here. Others who cannot make the journey bring the ashes later, to immerse them in the river.

The legend of Manikarnika

Manikarnika takes its name from a story. In one version, Shiva and Parvati were bathing in a sacred pool here, dug by Vishnu, when one of Parvati's jewelled earrings (*mani-karnika*, "jewel of the ear") fell into the water and was lost. In another version, it was Shiva's earring that fell as he trembled with joy at Vishnu's devotion. Either way, the pool became known as the **Manikarnika Kund**, and it still exists just above the ghat, a deep stone tank considered among the most sacred spots in the city.

The ghat beside it is among the oldest and most important cremation sites in India. Pyres burn here day and night, every day of the year. Estimates of how many cremations take place daily vary widely, but on a typical day it is many dozens, and during certain seasons more. The fires, as the saying goes, never go out.

The keepers of the fire: the Dom community

The cremation grounds of Varanasi are run by members of the **Dom** community, a hereditary group who have performed this work for generations. They manage the pyres, the fire and the cremation process, and they have historically held the right to provide the sacred fire with which each pyre is lit.

Traditionally, the Doms were placed at the margins of the caste system because their work involves death, which is considered ritually polluting. And yet without them, no one in Kashi could attain the liberation the city promises. This paradox is at the heart of the story of King Harishchandra, which we will come to in a moment.

The head of the Dom community has been known traditionally as the **Dom Raja**, "king of the Doms," a title that reflects both the community's status at the burning ghats and their importance to the city's sacred economy.

According to belief, the fire kept burning at Manikarnika has been maintained continuously for an immense length of time, and pyres are lit from this sacred flame. Whether you take that literally or not, the sense of continuity is real: the work is passed from parents to children, and the same families have tended these fires for generations.

What happens at a cremation

If you watch from a respectful distance, you may see some of these steps:

1. **The body is brought to the river.** It is dipped in the Ganga one final time, a last purifying bath.
2. **The body is placed on the pyre.** The pyre is built of wood, the quantity depending partly on what the family can afford. Sandalwood is sometimes added by families who can afford it.
3. **The chief mourner prepares.** This is usually the eldest son or a close male relative. He often has his head shaved and wears simple

white cloth.

4. **The fire is lit.** The chief mourner, after circling the pyre, lights it with fire taken from the sacred flame.
5. **The cremation proceeds** for several hours. Ghee and other offerings may be added.
6. **Kapal kriya.** In some traditions, at a certain point the skull is ritually cracked, believed to release the soul.
7. **The ashes are given to the river.** The remains are immersed in the Ganga.

You will notice that most mourners at the pyre are men. Traditionally, in many communities, women did not attend the cremation itself, partly from custom and partly, it is said, so that grief would not hold the soul back. Practices are changing, and you may sometimes see women present.

You may also notice the absence of loud weeping. In Kashi, the mood at the burning ghats is often calm, even matter-of-fact. Death here is understood as a passage, and excessive grief is sometimes believed to trouble the departing soul.

DID YOU KNOW?

Traditionally, certain people were not cremated in Kashi but given to the river directly, because they were considered already pure or because their deaths were considered special: young children, sadhus and holy men, and in some customs, victims of snakebite. Many of these practices are now restricted or discouraged, but you may hear them mentioned.

Harishchandra Ghat and the truthful king

Varanasi has a second cremation ghat, smaller and further south, called **Harishchandra Ghat**. It is named after **Raja Harishchandra**, a legendary king famous across India for his unbending commitment to

truth.

In the story, the sage **Vishwamitra** tests Harishchandra's honesty by demanding that he give up his entire kingdom in fulfilment of a promise. Harishchandra does so without complaint. Still in debt to the sage, he sells his wife and son into servitude and then sells himself to a Dom who works at the cremation ground in Kashi. The once-great king now tends funeral pyres and collects the cremation fees.

One day, his own wife arrives at the ghat carrying the body of their son, who has died of a snakebite. She has no money for the cremation fee. Harishchandra recognises them, and his heart breaks, but his duty to his master and his commitment to truth do not allow him to waive the fee. His wife offers the only thing she has, half of her own sari. At that moment, the gods appear, praise Harishchandra's integrity, restore his son to life and return the family to their kingdom.

The legend is told to Indian schoolchildren to this day. It is a story about truth, but it is also a story about the dignity of the work done at the burning ghats, a dignity so great that a king who did it faithfully became an example for all time.

Harishchandra Ghat today also houses an electric crematorium alongside traditional pyres.

Mukti Bhawan: the houses for the dying

Not far from the river, in the lanes of the old city, are a small number of guesthouses with an unusual purpose. They are places where elderly or seriously ill people come, often with family members, to spend their final days in Kashi, in the hope of dying in the sacred city and attaining liberation.

The best known is **Mukti Bhawan** ("House of Liberation"), established in 1958 by a charitable trust founded by the industrialist family of Vishnu Hari Dalmia. It is not a hospital and not a hotel. It is a simple building

with plain rooms where guests stay for a limited period, traditionally around two weeks. If death does not come within that time, guests are generally expected to return home, though exceptions are reportedly made. Daily life there revolves around prayer, hymn-singing and the recitation of sacred texts. Several such houses have existed in Varanasi.

These places are not tourist attractions. They are homes for people living through the most intimate passage of their lives. Please do not visit them out of curiosity, and do not photograph them. If you want to learn more, the 2016 Indian film *Hotel Salvation* (titled *Mukti Bhawan* in Hindi) is a gentle, humorous and moving fictional portrait of a family who come to such a house.

Etiquette at the burning ghats

You are allowed to visit Manikarnika and Harishchandra ghats. Many visitors find it among the most profound experiences of their lives. But this is a place of grief and sacred ritual, and the rules here are not optional.

- **Absolutely no photography or video of the cremations.** This is the single most important rule. You are watching someone's mother, father or child being cremated. Families find it deeply offensive, and people at the ghat may angrily intervene. Even a phone held up casually will be noticed. Keep it in your pocket.
- **Keep a respectful distance.** Watch from the upper steps or the surrounding buildings, not from beside the pyres.
- **Dress modestly** and keep your voice low.
- **Do not laugh, joke or pose** anywhere near the cremation area.
- **Do not get in the way.** Bodies are carried through the narrow lanes quickly. If you hear the chant approaching, step aside against the wall.
- **From the river is fine.** It is acceptable to pass by on a boat and observe quietly, but still without cameras pointed at the pyres.

The wood-donation warning

I need to share an honest warning here, not to make you suspicious of everyone, but so that your visit to this sacred place is not spoiled.

At Manikarnika, foreigners are frequently approached by men who present themselves as volunteers, guides, priests or caretakers of a hospice for the dying. They are often polite and well-informed. They will lead you to a vantage point, explain the cremation rituals, sometimes very movingly, and then tell you about the poor elderly people who are waiting to die and cannot afford wood for their cremation. They will ask you to donate money for wood, usually priced "per kilo," and the amounts quickly reach thousands of rupees.

In many cases, this is a well-rehearsed scam. The money does not go where you are told it will.

If you genuinely want to support the dying and the poor in Varanasi, do so through a registered charity whose details you can check independently, not through a stranger at the ghat. If someone approaches you, a polite and firm "No, thank you, I just want to sit quietly" is enough. You do not need a guide to sit and watch. The ghat is public.

LOCAL TIP

The calmest way to experience Manikarnika is from the river, on an early morning boat, or by sitting quietly at a distance on the steps of a nearby ghat. Avoid entering the cremation area itself with someone who has "offered" to show you around.

A reflection

Most of us live in cultures that hide death away. We rarely see a body, rarely see the process of returning it to the elements, and rarely talk openly about the end of our own lives.

Kashi offers a different way of seeing. Here, the fires burn in full view of the bathers, the boatmen, the chai sellers and the children flying kites. Life goes on around death without fear and without denial. Many visitors tell me that an hour at Manikarnika changed how they think about their own lives: what they want to do with their time, whom they want to love, what they want to let go of.

That, perhaps, is the deepest gift this city offers. Not a sight, but a question.



CHAPTER 4

Ganga Aarti Decoded

The ceremony everyone comes to see

If there is one ritual that has become the face of Varanasi to the world, it is the evening **Ganga Aarti** at Dashashwamedh Ghat. Every single evening, as the sun sets, a group of young priests in matching robes, usually seven of them, stand on raised wooden platforms facing the river and perform a synchronised offering of fire, sound, smoke and light to the goddess Ganga. Bells ring, conches blow, cymbals clash, a singer leads the crowd in devotional song, and huge multi-tiered brass lamps swing in great circles of flame over the darkening water.

It is magnificent. It is also, for most visitors, mysterious. What exactly are the priests doing? Why the fans? Why the feathers? Why the fire?

This chapter decodes the aarti step by step, so that when you sit on those steps or watch from a boat, you can read the language of the ritual.

What "aarti" means

Aarti is a form of worship in which light from a flame is offered to a deity, usually by moving a lamp in circles before the image or symbol of the divine. It is performed in homes and temples across India, often at dawn and dusk, sometimes several times a day. A family aarti at home might use a single small lamp with a cotton wick soaked in ghee. The Ganga Aarti is the same essential act magnified to the scale of the river.

In traditional understanding, aarti is a way of honouring a deity as a beloved and royal guest. Light dispels darkness, both literal and spiritual. Moving the flame before the deity is like illuminating their form so that it can be seen, and seeing the divine, called **darshan**, is at the heart of Hindu devotion. At the end, the flame, now considered blessed, is brought to the worshippers, who pass their hands over it and touch their eyes and head, taking the blessing into themselves.

In the Ganga Aarti, the deity is the river herself, and she is being honoured as a goddess at the close of the day.

The offerings, one by one

The aarti is structured as a series of offerings, each using a different object. The exact order can vary slightly between groups and between evenings, but the core elements are consistent. Many priests and devotees explain the sequence as an offering of the five elements and the senses to the goddess. Here is what you will see and, in common interpretation, what each means.

The conch (shankh)

The aarti typically opens with the blowing of conch shells. The long, deep, wavering sound of the **shankh** has been used in Hindu ritual for thousands of years. It is associated with Vishnu, who holds a conch in one hand, and with the primal sound of creation. The conch is believed to

purify the atmosphere and announce the presence of the divine. When the conches sound across the river, you will often feel the crowd fall still.

Incense (dhoop and agarbatti)

The priests offer incense, waving it in circles toward the river. Fragrance is an offering to the sense of smell, and the smoke rising upward is a natural symbol of prayer ascending. In the five-element reading, incense, made from earth's resins and plants, is often associated with the element of **earth**.

The lamps (deep)

This is the visual heart of the aarti. The priests lift heavy brass lamps, some with many tiers of flame in a cobra-hood or tree shape, and move them in large, slow, clockwise circles, first toward the river and then in each direction. The flames trace patterns of light in the dark air and reflect in the water.

Fire, **Agni**, is the element of transformation and the traditional messenger between humans and gods. Offering light honours the goddess and symbolises the dispelling of ignorance. Smaller single lamps and a camphor flame (**kapoor**) are also used. Camphor burns completely without leaving residue, and is sometimes said to represent the ego burning away entirely in the presence of the divine.

The yak-tail fan (chamar or chanwar)

Next, the priests wave a whisk made of white yak hair on a handle. In ancient India, the **chamar** was a symbol of royalty, waved by attendants to fan kings and keep insects away. Fanning a deity with a chamar honours them as sovereign. In the elemental reading, the moving air represents the element of **air**.

The peacock-feather fan (morpankh)

Some aartis also include a fan made of peacock feathers. Like the chamar, it is a royal and auspicious object, and the peacock is associated with several deities, including Krishna, who wears a peacock feather in his crown, and Kartikeya, Shiva's son, who rides a peacock. The gentle fanning is a gesture of loving service, cooling and comforting the goddess as one would an honoured guest.

Water, flowers and the final offering

Flowers (**pushpa**), especially marigolds and rose petals, are offered to the river and sometimes showered over the crowd near the end. Flowers represent the beauty and fragility of life and the offering of the heart. Water may be offered from a small pot. Through the whole ceremony, bells (**ghanta**) ring continuously, and a lead singer and musicians lead hymns such as *Om Jai Gange Mata*, which many in the crowd will sing along with.

Some interpreters complete the five-element scheme by linking the sound of the conch and bells to **space** (ether, *akasha*), and the water and flowers to **water**. Whether or not the priests consciously follow this scheme on a given night, the idea of offering the whole of creation back to the goddess is a beautiful way to watch.

The conclusion

At the end, the lamps are brought to the edge of the platform and the crowd reaches toward them, passing their palms over the flames and then touching their eyes and foreheads. You are welcome to do the same. Pass your hands gently over the flame, a few centimetres above it, then bring them to your face. It is a gesture of receiving blessing, and nobody will mind that you are a visitor.

DID YOU KNOW?

The circular movement of the lamp is traditionally made in a clockwise direction, keeping the deity always to the right of the worshipper. The same principle governs **pradakshina**, the clockwise walk around temples and sacred objects that you will see devotees perform throughout Varanasi.

Dashashwamedh: the evening aarti

Dashashwamedh Ghat is the central and busiest ghat in Varanasi, and its name comes from a legend. Brahma, the creator, is said to have performed the **Dashashwamedha**, a sacrifice of ten horses, here. Some accounts link this to welcoming Shiva back to Kashi. Today it is the main gateway between the old city and the river, packed with pilgrims, boatmen, flower sellers and priests under bamboo umbrellas.

The evening aarti takes place here every day, regardless of weather or season. There are usually two aarti platforms performing at the same time on the Dashashwamedh stretch, organised by local committees. Both are worth watching.

Approximate timing by season

The aarti is linked to sunset, so its start time shifts throughout the year. These are approximate:

Season	Approximate start
October to February	around 6:00 PM (as early as 5:45 PM in mid-winter)
March to May	around 6:30 PM
June to September	around 7:00 PM

The ceremony lasts roughly 40 to 50 minutes. Please confirm locally on the day, as timings shift with sunset and occasionally with special events.

Where to watch from

You have three main options, each with a different emotional texture:

- **The ghat steps.** Free, immersive and crowded. You feel the heat of the lamps and smell the incense. Arrive 45 to 60 minutes early in peak season to get a decent spot, and do not stand up once it starts.
- **A boat on the river.** You face the priests directly and see the whole ceremony at once, with the reflections on the water. Calmer and more panoramic, but less intimate. Arrange your boat in advance and agree the price before you board.
- **A rooftop or balcony.** Comfortable and good for photographs, but distant. Many visitors feel they watched the aarti rather than experienced it.

My honest recommendation is to experience it at least once from the steps, and if you have a second evening, once from a boat.

Assi Ghat: the morning aarti, Subah-e-Banaras

If the evening aarti is a grand public spectacle, the morning ceremony at **Assi Ghat** is its quieter, more contemplative sibling. Known as **Subah-e-Banaras**, "Morning of Banaras," it takes place at dawn and combines a Ganga aarti, Vedic chanting, live classical music and often a short session of yoga.

The crowd is smaller and more local, the mood gentler, and you can usually find a good spot without arriving very early. For a spiritual traveller, it is in many ways the more nourishing of the two. It also pairs naturally with a sunrise boat ride that leaves from Assi immediately afterwards.

The morning ceremony usually starts before sunrise, roughly between 4:45 and 6:00 AM depending on season. Check locally the day before.

LOCAL TIP

If you can only do one aarti and you are a light sleeper or an early riser, choose Subah-e-Banaras. If you want the full spectacle, choose Dashashwamedh in the evening. If you can, do both, on different days.

How to offer a diya

Around the ghats, especially near aarti time, you will see children and women selling small **diyas**: little bowls made of dried leaves or clay, filled with marigold petals and a small candle or ghee wick. Floating a diya on the Ganga is one of the simplest and most beautiful acts you can do in Varanasi.

Here is how to do it respectfully:

1. **Buy your diya** from one of the sellers. The price is usually modest, typically ₹10 to ₹20. You do not need to buy many; one is enough.
2. **Hold it in both hands** and go down to the water's edge, or offer it from a boat.
3. **Light the wick.** The seller may light it for you, or you can light it from someone else's diya.
4. **Take a moment.** Make a silent prayer, a wish, or a dedication. Many people offer a diya in memory of someone they have lost, or for the wellbeing of their family.
5. **Lower it gently** onto the water with both hands and let the current carry it away. Do not push it out forcefully.

Watching your small flame join hundreds of others drifting downstream in the dark is something people remember for a very long time.

LOCAL TIP

Some leaf diyas contain a small plastic or foil element. If you have a choice, pick one made entirely of leaves and petals, which is kinder to the river.

Aarti etiquette

- **Photography is generally fine** during the aarti, unlike at the cremation ghats. But never use flash in someone's face, and do not stand up in front of seated people to take a picture.
- **Dress modestly.** Shoulders and knees covered is respectful.
- **Watch for pickpockets** in the dense crowd. Keep valuables close.
- **Ignore "VIP seat" sellers.** There are no official paid VIP seats at the aarti. If someone offers a reserved chair for a high price, you can politely decline and find a place on the steps.
- **Donations are voluntary.** You may see donation boxes or be approached for contributions. Give only if you wish, and preferably into an official box.
- **Join in if you feel moved.** Clapping along with the hymns, singing the refrain, or folding your hands are all welcome.



CHAPTER 5

The Ghats That Matter

A necklace of stone

The ghats are the soul of the riverfront: broad stone stairways descending into the water, each with its own temples, shrines, bathing platforms and stories. Many were built or rebuilt in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries by Maratha, Rajput and other royal families who wanted a foothold in the holiest city in India. Others are far older in their sacred associations, even if the stonework is recent.

You can walk most of the riverfront from Assi in the south to Panchganga in the north in two or three unhurried hours, outside monsoon. Here are the ghats I would want every spiritual traveller to know, in order from south to north.

Assi Ghat

The southernmost of the major ghats, at the meeting point of the old Assi stream and the Ganga. A Shiva lingam beneath a pipal tree here is honoured as **Asisangameshwar**, the lord of the confluence. Tradition holds that Tulsidas, the great poet-saint, lived and died nearby.

Assi is the most relaxed of the main ghats and the hub for many long-stay travellers, yoga students and university folk from nearby BHU. It hosts the morning Subah-e-Banaras ceremony and a smaller evening aarti. It is a good place to start your walks, and your sunrise boat.

Tulsi Ghat

Named after **Goswami Tulsidas** (sixteenth century), author of the *Ramcharitmanas*, the beloved retelling of the Ramayana in the Awadhi language that is still sung in homes across northern India. Tradition says he composed part of this work while living here. The ghat preserves objects associated with him and is home to a traditional wrestling ground, an **akhara**, where young men train in the old style of Indian wrestling, smearing themselves with earth.

Tulsi Ghat is also the stage for **Nag Nathaiya**, a spectacular festival re-enactment of Krishna's victory over the serpent Kaliya, described in Chapter 9.

Kedar Ghat

Kedar Ghat is easy to spot from the river by its steps painted in bold red and white stripes. At the top stands the **Kedareshwar** temple, a Shiva shrine honouring the same form of Shiva worshipped at Kedarnath in the Himalayas. Pilgrims believe that worshipping here brings the merit of that distant mountain pilgrimage.

The area around Kedar Ghat has a strong South Indian, and particularly Bengali and Tamil, flavour, home to many pilgrims and families who settled in Kashi over centuries. It is one of my own favourite stretches. As a boy, I spent long afternoons on these steps watching the boats, and I still find it one of the calmest places to sit on the whole riverfront.

Harishchandra Ghat

The second cremation ghat, smaller than Manikarnika, named after the legendary truthful king whose story is told in Chapter 3. Please observe the same strict no-photography etiquette as at Manikarnika.

Chet Singh Ghat

A fortified ghat with an imposing palace-like structure, associated with **Maharaja Chet Singh** of Benares. In 1781 it was the scene of a confrontation between the Maharaja's forces and the troops of **Warren Hastings**, Governor-General of the British East India Company, who had come to demand money from him. The clash ended badly for the British in the short term, and Hastings had to flee the city, though Chet Singh was later deposed. The ghat is a reminder that Varanasi's history is political as well as sacred.

Darbhangha Ghat

One of the most photographed ghats, dominated by a grand palace built by the royal family of **Darbhangha** in Bihar in the early twentieth century, with tall sandstone columns facing the river. The building has since been converted into a heritage hotel. Next to it stands the **Munshi Ghat** building. Together they form one of the most dramatic facades on the riverfront.

Dashashwamedh Ghat

The central ghat and the main entry point from the city to the river, associated with Brahma's legendary ten-horse sacrifice. It is the site of the evening Ganga Aarti and the busiest point on the riverfront at any hour. Here you will find priests (often called **pandas** or **ghatias**) sitting under large bamboo umbrellas, offering to perform rituals, apply tilak, or hold your belongings while you bathe. Dashashwamedh is crowded, loud and full of life. It is also where you will be approached most often by touts, so keep your wits about you.

Manikarnika Ghat

The great cremation ghat, described in Chapter 3, and one of the most sacred places in Kashi. Above the ghat lies the **Manikarnika Kund**, the sacred pool, and beside it a slab traditionally said to bear the footprints of Vishnu, called the **Charan Paduka**. Remember: no photographs of cremations.

DID YOU KNOW?

Near Manikarnika you may notice a temple leaning dramatically, its spire tilted and its base partly submerged for much of the year. This is the **Ratneshwar Mahadev** temple, and its tilt is so pronounced that it is sometimes compared to the Leaning Tower of Pisa. Locals tell several stories to explain it, including one about a debt to a mother that a son could never repay.

Scindia Ghat

Just north of Manikarnika, built by the **Scindia** royal family of Gwalior in the nineteenth century. It is believed by some to be the place where Agni, the god of fire, was born. The ghat's heavy construction partly collapsed into the river during building, which is one popular explanation

for the sunken, tilted shrine near the water's edge, though different sources attribute the tilted temple to different neighbouring ghats. The lanes above Scindia Ghat are among the most atmospheric in the old city, full of tiny shrines.

Panchganga Ghat

Panchganga, "five rivers," is so called because, according to belief, five sacred rivers meet here: the Ganga and four others that flow invisibly beneath the surface, named in tradition as the Yamuna, Saraswati, Kirana and Dhutapapa. Bathing here, especially during the month of Kartik, is considered especially meritorious.

During Kartik (roughly October to November), devotees hang small lamps in baskets on tall bamboo poles, called **akash deep** or "sky lamps," to light the way for the souls of ancestors. Above the ghat stands the **Alamgir Mosque**, built in the seventeenth century during the reign of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb, on a site where a large Vishnu temple, Bindu Madhav, is recorded to have stood. A smaller Bindu Madhav temple remains nearby. Few places capture Varanasi's layered, complicated history so vividly.

The sunrise boat as meditation

There is no better way to see the ghats as a whole than from a rowing boat at sunrise. Most people treat it as sightseeing, pointing and photographing. I want to suggest a different approach: treat it as a moving meditation.

Before you board

- **Book a reliable boat or agree the price clearly before boarding.** A private rowing boat for a small group typically costs roughly ₹600 to ₹1,200 for 1.5 to 2 hours, depending on season and route. Agree the full price, the duration and the route before you step

aboard.

- **Choose a rowing boat over a motorboat if you can.** It is slower, quieter and infinitely more peaceful.
- **Start from Assi** if you want calm, or Dashashwamedh if you want to be close to the centre.
- **Bring a shawl** in winter. Mornings on the water from December to February are surprisingly cold, and fog is common.

A simple practice for the boat

1. **The first ten minutes: silence.** Ask your boatman, politely, if you may have some quiet. Do not take photos yet. Just watch the darkness turn grey and then pink. Breathe slowly.
2. **As the sun breaks: offer something.** You might simply fold your hands, or offer a diya, or silently dedicate the morning to someone you love.
3. **As you pass the bathers: observe without judging.** Notice the devotion in an old woman's raised hands, the boys diving, the priest's murmured mantras. Let each scene pass like a thought in meditation.
4. **As you pass Manikarnika: pause.** Put away your camera. Watch the smoke rise. Reflect quietly on impermanence.
5. **On the return: let yourself feel.** Notice what has moved you. Many people find tears come unexpectedly on this stretch. Let them.
6. **Then take your photographs.** By now the light is full and golden, and you have already had the experience. The photos are a souvenir, not the point.

LOCAL TIP

Ask your boatman about his family. Many boatmen in Varanasi come from the traditional **Mallah** community and have worked on the river for generations. Their knowledge of the ghats, the river's moods and the city's gossip is extraordinary, and a sincere question often turns a transaction into a friendship.



CHAPTER 6

The Temples of Kashi

A city of shrines

It is said that every stone in Kashi is a Shiva lingam. Walk the old city for an hour and you will believe it. There are temples in courtyards, temples in wall niches, temples under trees, temples so small you could hold them in your arms. Estimates of the number of shrines in Varanasi run into the thousands. You cannot visit them all, and you should not try. Here are the temples most meaningful to a spiritual traveller, with practical etiquette for each.

General temple etiquette

Before we visit individual temples, a few principles apply almost everywhere:

- **Remove your shoes** before entering. Most temples have a place to leave them, sometimes for a small fee or tip.
- **Dress modestly.** Shoulders and knees covered for everyone. Loose, light clothing is ideal.
- **Do not touch the deity or the lingam** unless you see that others are doing so and it is clearly permitted. In some temples, touching the lingam is customary; in others it is not.
- **Walk clockwise** around shrines and sanctums.
- **Do not photograph inside sanctums** unless clearly permitted. Many temples ban photography entirely.
- **Leather** items such as belts and bags are not welcome in many temples. Leave them behind if you can.
- **Do not hand money directly to the idol or to strangers** who approach you. Use official donation boxes.

Kashi Vishwanath Temple

The Lord of the Universe

The **Kashi Vishwanath Temple** is the spiritual centre of the city and one of the most important temples in India. It is dedicated to Shiva as **Vishwanath** or **Vishweshwara**, "Lord of the Universe," and houses one of the twelve **Jyotirlingas**, the most sacred Shiva shrines in India, where Shiva is believed to have manifested as a pillar of infinite light.

The temple's history is long and painful. Earlier temples on or near this site were destroyed and rebuilt several times over the centuries. The present temple was built in about 1780 by **Ahilyabai Holkar**, the remarkable Maratha queen of Indore, who also rebuilt and endowed temples across India. Its spire and dome were later covered in gold, donated by **Maharaja Ranjit Singh** of Punjab in the nineteenth century, which is why it is sometimes called the Golden Temple of Varanasi. Beside it stands the **Gyanvapi Mosque**, built in the

seventeenth century, and the area is a subject of ongoing legal and political dispute. I mention this not to take sides, but so you understand the heavy security you will see.

The Kashi Vishwanath Dham corridor

On 13 December 2021, the **Shri Kashi Vishwanath Dham** corridor was inaugurated. This large redevelopment cleared many old buildings between the temple and the river, creating a wide paved complex that connects the temple directly to the ghats. It includes courtyards, galleries, facilities for pilgrims, and an approach from the river near Lalita Ghat.

Opinions in Varanasi about the corridor are mixed. Many pilgrims, especially the elderly, welcome the easier access, the cleanliness and the space. Others mourn the loss of the old lanes, homes and small shrines that were cleared to make way for it. Both feelings are real, and you will meet both among locals.

Practical rules for visiting

Security at Kashi Vishwanath is strict. The rules change from time to time, so check locally or on the official temple website (shrikashivishwanath.org) before you go. As a general guide:

- **Phones are not allowed inside.** Mobile phones, cameras, smartwatches, power banks and other electronic devices must be deposited before entry. Bags, pens and leather items are also typically not allowed.
- **Lockers are provided** near the entry points for phones and belongings. They have often been free or very cheap, but check the current arrangement on the day.
- **Foreign visitors are generally allowed** to enter for darshan. Bring your **original passport**, not a copy, as you may be asked for it at the security check. There has often been a designated entry gate for foreign visitors. Ask the security staff at the gate which entrance to

use.

- **Dress modestly.** There is no strict official dress code for general darshan in the sense of mandatory traditional clothing, but shoulders and knees should be covered, and the temple has offered saris to women whose clothes are too short. Some special ceremonies have stricter dress requirements, so check if you book one.
- **Remove your shoes** at the designated area.
- **Expect queues.** General darshan is free, but queues can be very long, especially on Mondays (Shiva's day), during the month of Shravan (roughly July to August), on festivals and at weekends.
- **Sugam darshan** is a paid "easy darshan" option with a shorter queue, bookable through the official website. Special aartis, such as the pre-dawn **Mangala Aarti**, also require advance booking on the official site and sell out quickly.

LOCAL TIP

Do not pay touts in the lanes who offer "VIP darshan" or "quick entry" for a fee. Book any paid darshan only through the official website or official counters. If someone offers to hold your phone or shoes for money and take you in "through a shortcut," politely decline.

What happens inside

After security, you walk through the corridor to the inner temple. The sanctum is small and usually crowded. Devotees offer water, milk, flowers and **bel** leaves (sacred to Shiva) to the lingam. The moment of darshan is often brief, a few seconds before the crowd moves you on. Do not be disappointed. In the Hindu understanding, even a moment's glimpse of the divine is complete.

Kal Bhairav Temple

Kal Bhairav is a fierce form of Shiva, and in Kashi he holds a special role as the **Kotwal**, the city's police chief or guardian. According to belief, he keeps the record of every soul in Kashi, and nobody can stay in the city, or die in it and receive liberation, without his permission. Traditionally, pilgrims visit Kal Bhairav to seek his blessing, and many Banarasis say that a visit to Kashi is incomplete without it.

Kal Bhairav is associated with a dog, which is his vehicle, so you may see dogs treated with unusual kindness around the temple. Devotees tie a black thread on their wrists after visiting, believed to protect against harm. The temple is small, crowded and intense, with a distinctly different energy from Vishwanath. Expect a short queue, and keep your belongings close.

Annapurna Temple

Close to Kashi Vishwanath stands the temple of **Annapurna**, the goddess of food and nourishment, a form of Parvati. In a well-known story, Shiva once declared that the material world, including food, was an illusion. Parvati, to prove the importance of the material, disappeared, and the world was struck by famine. Shiva himself was forced to beg for food, and Parvati appeared in Kashi as Annapurna, feeding him from her ladle. Since then, it is believed, nobody in Kashi goes to sleep hungry.

The present temple dates from the eighteenth century. At the festival of **Annakut**, the day after Diwali, the temple is decorated with mountains of food offerings. A golden image of Annapurna is displayed to the public on only a few days a year around Diwali, and the queues are enormous.

DID YOU KNOW?

An old stone statue of Annapurna, believed to have been taken from Varanasi early in the twentieth century, was returned from Canada to India in 2021 and reinstalled in Kashi. It was a moving moment for many in the city.

Sankat Mochan Hanuman Temple

The **Sankat Mochan** temple is dedicated to **Hanuman**, the monkey god, whose name here means "reliever of troubles." Tradition associates its founding with Tulsidas, who is said to have had a vision of Hanuman at this spot. The temple sits in a leafy compound in the southern part of the city, near BHU, and is home to many monkeys. Keep food out of sight and hold your belongings firmly.

Tuesdays and Saturdays, Hanuman's days, are especially busy, with devotees reciting the **Hanuman Chalisa**, a forty-verse hymn. The temple is also famous for the **Sankat Mochan Sangeet Samaroh**, an annual music festival in spring at which India's greatest classical musicians perform through the night as an offering. Phones are typically not allowed inside, and lockers are available; check locally.

Durga Temple

The **Durga Kund** temple, a striking red-ochre building in the north Indian **nagara** style, stands beside a large stone tank. It was built in the eighteenth century, traditionally credited to a Bengali queen, Rani Bhabani of Natore. Durga, the warrior goddess, is especially honoured here during the autumn festival of **Navratri**. The temple is sometimes called the "Monkey Temple" for the monkeys in the area. Note that non-Hindus may be restricted from the innermost sanctum, so follow staff instructions.

Tulsi Manas Mandir

Just next to the Durga temple is the **Tulsi Manas Mandir**, a white marble temple built in 1964 at the place where tradition says Tulsidas composed the *Ramcharitmanas*. Its walls are inscribed with verses from the epic, and it has a peaceful garden atmosphere. It is a good place for a quiet sit after the intensity of the old city.

Bharat Mata Mandir

One of the most unusual temples in India, the **Bharat Mata Mandir** ("Mother India Temple") was inaugurated in 1936 by **Mahatma Gandhi**. It contains no traditional deity. Instead, its centrepiece is a large relief map of undivided India carved in marble, showing mountains, rivers and plains in detail. It was intended as a temple to the motherland and to national unity at a time when India was struggling for independence. It is located within the campus of the Mahatma Gandhi Kashi Vidyapith, a short drive from the old city.

New Vishwanath Temple at BHU

On the leafy campus of **Banaras Hindu University** stands the tall white marble **New Vishwanath Temple**, also called the **Birla Mandir**, built by the Birla family and completed in the 1960s. It was conceived by the university's founder, Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya, as a place where everyone, regardless of caste or religion, could worship. Its spire is among the tallest of any temple in India.

The atmosphere here is very different from the old city: spacious, calm, and unhurried. Visitors of all backgrounds are welcome, and photography rules are generally more relaxed than in the old temples, though not inside the sanctum. If you found the crowds at Kashi Vishwanath overwhelming, come here to sit quietly.

LOCAL TIP

Temple timings in Varanasi often include a mid-day closure, when the deity is believed to rest. If you arrive at a closed temple in the early afternoon, it is not a mistake. Wait or come back later.



CHAPTER 7

Sarnath: Where the Wheel Began to Turn

The deer park

About 10 kilometres north-east of the ghats lies **Sarnath**, one of the four most sacred places in Buddhism. Around two and a half thousand years ago, a wandering teacher who had recently attained enlightenment under a tree at Bodh Gaya walked here to find five former companions who were practising austerities in a deer park called **Isipatana** or **Mrigadava**. To them he gave his first teaching.

The teacher was **Siddhartha Gautama**, the **Buddha**, "the awakened one." His first sermon, known as the **Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta**, "setting in motion the wheel of the Dharma," laid out the **Four Noble Truths** (that life involves suffering, that suffering has a cause in craving, that it can end, and that there is a path to its ending) and the **Noble Eightfold Path**. The five listeners became the first monks, and the Buddhist **Sangha**, the community of practitioners, was born here.

After the noise and fire of the ghats, Sarnath feels like a long exhale. It is green, quiet and spacious. Pilgrims from Sri Lanka, Thailand, Myanmar, Tibet, Japan and many other countries come here in robes of saffron, maroon and grey, and you will often hear chanting in several languages drifting across the lawns.

What to see

Dhamek Stupa

The great cylindrical **Dhamek Stupa**, about 43 metres tall, is the landmark of Sarnath. It is traditionally believed to mark the spot where the Buddha gave his first sermon. The structure you see today largely dates from around the fifth or sixth century CE, in the Gupta period, built over earlier foundations going back to the time of the emperor **Ashoka** in the third century BCE. Its lower section is decorated with delicate carved floral and geometric patterns.

Pilgrims walk slowly around it clockwise, often chanting, and some press small squares of gold leaf onto its stones. Join the circumambulation quietly if you wish. It is a beautiful walking meditation.

The archaeological park and Ashoka pillar

Around the stupa lies a large park of excavated ruins: the foundations of monasteries, shrines and smaller stupas, built and rebuilt over more than a thousand years. Among them stands the broken stump of an **Ashokan pillar**, protected under a small enclosure, bearing an inscription from the emperor Ashoka.

Ashoka, who ruled much of the Indian subcontinent in the third century BCE, turned toward Buddhism after the horrors of his war against Kalinga, and erected pillars across his empire inscribed with edicts on ethics, tolerance and compassion.

The Lion Capital in the Sarnath Museum

The top of that pillar, the **Lion Capital of Ashoka**, was excavated here in the early twentieth century and is now kept in the **Sarnath Archaeological Museum**, a short walk away. Four lions sit back to back above a band carved with animals and wheels. It is one of the finest pieces of ancient Indian sculpture, polished to an almost glassy finish, and it is the source of **India's national emblem**. The wheel on the abacus, the **Dharma Chakra**, also appears at the centre of India's national flag.

The museum also holds a celebrated seated Buddha image of the Gupta period, showing the Buddha teaching, with a serene, inward expression that many consider one of the most beautiful Buddha images ever made.

LOCAL TIP

The Sarnath Archaeological Museum is **closed on Fridays**, and photography inside has generally not been allowed. Opening hours are typically from morning until about 5:00 PM. Check current hours and fees before you go, because they can change.

Mulagandha Kuti Vihara

A modern Buddhist temple, built in 1931 by the **Maha Bodhi Society** under the leadership of the Sri Lankan Buddhist reformer **Anagarika Dharmapala**. Inside, the walls are covered with murals depicting the life of the Buddha, painted by the Japanese artist **Kosetsu Nosu**. Behind the temple, a **Bodhi tree** grows that is said to have been propagated from the sacred tree at Anuradhapura in Sri Lanka, itself traditionally grown from a cutting of the original tree at Bodh Gaya.

Chaukhandi Stupa and other sites

On the approach road stands the **Chaukhandi Stupa**, a brick mound believed to mark where the Buddha first met his five companions, topped

by an octagonal tower added in the Mughal period. Around Sarnath you will also find temples built by Buddhist communities from many countries, including Tibetan, Thai, Japanese and Sri Lankan temples, each in its own national style.

Sarnath is also sacred to Jains: a Digambar Jain temple near the Dhamek Stupa honours **Shreyansanath**, the eleventh Tirthankara, who according to Jain tradition was born nearby.

A respectful half-day itinerary

Time	What to do
8:30 AM	Leave the old city by auto, taxi or ride-hailing app (about 30 to 45 minutes)
9:15 AM	Chaukhandi Stupa, a brief stop on the way in
9:45 AM	Archaeological park and Dhamek Stupa; walk around the stupa slowly
10:45 AM	Sarnath Museum (not on Fridays)
11:45 AM	Mulagandha Kuti Vihara and the Bodhi tree; sit for ten minutes
12:30 PM	Optional visit to one international temple, then return

Etiquette at Sarnath: Remove shoes where asked. Walk clockwise around stupas and shrines. Never sit with your back or feet pointed at a Buddha image, and never climb on images or stupas for photos. Speak softly near monks and meditators. If you see a monk, do not touch him without invitation, and women should take particular care not to touch monks of the stricter Theravada traditions.

DID YOU KNOW?

Buddhists sometimes call Sarnath the place where the Buddha "turned the wheel of the Dharma" for the first time. The image of the wheel set in motion is one reason the eight-spoked wheel became one of Buddhism's central symbols.



CHAPTER 8

Rituals You May Witness

The living ritual city

Varanasi is a city where religious ritual is not reserved for special occasions. It happens all day, everywhere, in the open. You will see it on the ghats, in the lanes, in shops where owners light incense before opening, at tea stalls where the first glass is set aside as an offering. This chapter will help you recognise what you are seeing, and how to take part, if you wish, without being exploited.

Puja

Puja is the general word for worship. A puja can be as simple as a single flower placed before a small image, or as elaborate as an hours-long ceremony led by several priests. A typical puja involves honouring a deity as an honoured guest: inviting them, offering water, flowers, incense,

light and food, and asking for their blessing. On the ghats, you will see priests seated under umbrellas performing pujas for pilgrims, with small brass plates of offerings, coconuts, flowers, red powder and sacred water.

Tilak

The mark on a person's forehead is called a **tilak** or **tika**. It can be red, white, yellow or black, made from sandalwood paste, vermilion, ash or turmeric. Different shapes indicate different traditions: three horizontal lines of ash, called **tripundra**, indicate a devotee of Shiva; a vertical U-shape often indicates a devotee of Vishnu. The forehead point between the eyebrows is associated with the "third eye," the seat of spiritual insight.

Priests on the ghats will often offer to apply a tilak to visitors. It is a lovely gesture, and you are welcome to accept, but be aware that it is often followed by a request for payment. More on that below.

The sacred thread

You may see men, particularly from Brahmin families, wearing a thin cotton thread looped over the left shoulder and across the body. This is the **janeu** or **yajnopavita**, the sacred thread, given in an initiation ceremony called **upanayana** that traditionally marks a boy's entry into formal religious study.

You will also see coloured threads, usually red and yellow, tied around wrists. This is the **kalava** or **mauli**, tied by a priest after a puja as a sign of blessing and protection. Priests at temples and ghats may offer to tie one for you.

Pind daan and shraddha

At certain ghats you will see families seated in a row before a priest, making small balls of rice, barley flour and sesame seeds, called **pinda**, and offering them with water and prayers. This is **pind daan**, an offering made for deceased ancestors to nourish and help them on their journey. These rites form part of **shraddha**, the ceremonies honouring ancestors, and are especially performed during **Pitru Paksha**, a fortnight in the lunar month of Bhadrapada or Ashvin (usually September or early October) dedicated to the ancestors. Please do not photograph families during these rites without clear permission.

Mundan

You will often see a barber on the ghat shaving someone's head, sometimes a small child, sometimes a grown man. This is **mundan**, ritual head-shaving. For a child it is a rite of passage, usually performed in the first few years of life and believed to remove impurities from a past birth. For adult men it is commonly a sign of mourning after the death of a parent, and also an act of devotion at sacred places.

Ganga snan and lamp offerings

We met **Ganga snan**, ritual bathing, in Chapter 2, and **deep daan**, the offering of lamps, in Chapter 4. You will see both every day. Watch especially for the elderly women who come at dawn, sometimes in small groups, singing as they bathe. Their songs are often centuries old.

How to receive prasad

Prasad is food that has been offered to a deity and is then returned to worshippers as a blessing. It may be a sweet, a piece of fruit, puffed rice, or a spoonful of sacred water. If someone offers you prasad at a temple or on the ghat:

- **Receive it with your right hand**, or with both hands cupped together, right over left. Never with the left hand alone.
- **Accept it graciously**. It is considered impolite to refuse prasad. If you cannot eat it for health reasons, accept it, touch it to your forehead, and quietly set it aside later or give it to someone else.
- **Do not throw it away** in front of the giver, and never put it on the floor.
- **Eat it, or share it**. Many people eat a small portion and share the rest.

What should a blessing cost?

Here is the honest answer: **a blessing costs nothing**.

In Hindu tradition, it is customary to make a small voluntary offering, called **dakshina**, to a priest who performs a ritual for you. This is a genuine and respectful custom. But in tourist areas of Varanasi, some people approach foreigners, apply a tilak, tie a thread or offer a quick prayer uninvited, and then demand a large sum, sometimes hundreds or even thousands of rupees, often with a story about feeding the poor or temple upkeep.

A few guidelines:

- **If you did not ask for the ritual, you are not obliged to pay for it**. If you want to avoid the situation altogether, smile and say "No, thank you" before the tilak reaches your forehead.
- **If you choose to accept a small blessing** like a tilak or a thread, a modest dakshina of ₹20 to ₹100 is generous and appropriate.
- **For a proper puja arranged in advance**, agree the dakshina clearly beforehand, just as you would agree any other service.
- **For donations to temples**, use official donation counters or boxes, ideally where a receipt is issued.

- **Never feel guilty** for declining. A sincere priest will not pressure you. Pressure itself is the sign that something is wrong.

LOCAL TIP

If you would like to have a genuine puja performed, perhaps for a loved one who has died, ask your guesthouse owner or a trusted local contact to arrange a priest for you, and agree the dakshina in advance. A puja arranged this way is a completely different experience from one pressed on you at the ghat.



CHAPTER 9

Festivals of Kashi

A city that celebrates

Varanasi has a saying that the city has "seven days and nine festivals." There is almost always something being celebrated somewhere. A handful of festivals, however, transform the whole city and are worth planning a trip around. Hindu festivals follow a lunar calendar, so their dates shift from year to year in the Western calendar. **Always verify dates for the year of your visit.**

Dev Deepawali

Dev Deepawali, "the Diwali of the gods," is Varanasi's most spectacular festival and unique to the city. It falls on **Kartik Purnima**, the full moon of the month of Kartik, about fifteen days after Diwali. On this night, it is believed, the gods descend to earth to bathe in the Ganga, and

the people of Kashi welcome them by lighting lamps along the entire riverfront. Hundreds of thousands, and in recent years reportedly over a million, clay lamps are lit on the steps of the ghats, from Assi to the far north, and on the far bank. Special aartis are performed, fireworks burst over the river, and the ghats glow golden for kilometres.

The festival also commemorates, in belief, Shiva's victory over the demon **Tripurasura**, and is linked to the month-long Kartik practice of lighting lamps for ancestors.

Dates: Dev Deepawali falls on **24 November 2026** and on **13 November 2027** (dates according to widely used Hindu calendars; verify each year, as some calendars differ by a day depending on the timing of the full moon).

LOCAL TIP

Dev Deepawali is the busiest night of the year. Hotels and boats are booked months in advance, and boat prices rise sharply. Book early, expect enormous crowds, and plan to arrive at the ghats by mid-afternoon. Watching from a boat gives the most sweeping view of the lamps.

Mahashivratri

Mahashivratri, "the great night of Shiva," falls in late February or March. Devotees fast, keep vigil through the night, and offer water, milk and bel leaves to the Shiva lingam. Huge queues form at Kashi Vishwanath, and processions celebrating Shiva's wedding to Parvati wind through the city with music, dancing and colourful tableaux. For many Banarasis, this is the most important festival of the year. Mahashivratri in 2027 is expected around **6 March 2027** (verify).

Holi in Kashi

Holi, the festival of colours, marks the arrival of spring, usually in March. In Varanasi, the celebrations start early, with music, colour and **thandai** (a spiced milk drink, sometimes laced with bhang; see Chapter 12). On the day itself, the streets and ghats explode with coloured powder and water. Holi in 2027 is expected around **22 March 2027** (verify).

The season has two distinctive Kashi traditions:

- **Rangbhari Ekadashi**, a few days before Holi, when, according to tradition, Shiva brings Parvati home to Kashi after their marriage. Devotees play with colour at Kashi Vishwanath, and the festival season of Holi in Varanasi formally begins.
- **Masan Holi** (also called Masane ki Holi or Chita Bhasm Holi), usually held the day after Rangbhari Ekadashi at Manikarnika and Harishchandra ghats. Here, some devotees, especially ascetics and devotees of Shiva, play Holi with ash from the cremation grounds, recalling Shiva's association with the burning ground and with death as part of life. It is an intense, loud and crowded event. In recent years it has also drawn very large crowds of visitors and media attention, and some local religious bodies have debated its form and who should take part. If you attend, do so as a respectful observer, be prepared for chaos, and keep your camera away from the pyres.

LOCAL TIP

Holi in Varanasi can be very rowdy, especially in the old city and around the ghats. Many solo travellers, particularly women, prefer to celebrate with a trusted group or at their guesthouse. Wear old clothes, oil your skin and hair beforehand so the colour washes out more easily, and protect your phone and eyes.

Diwali

Diwali, the festival of lights, falls in October or November, on the new moon of Kartik. Homes and shops are cleaned and lit with lamps, Lakshmi, the goddess of prosperity, is worshipped, and fireworks fill the night. The day after Diwali is **Annakut**, when the Annapurna temple displays its mountains of food offerings. Diwali in 2026 falls on **20 October 2026** (verify).

Ganga Dussehra

Ganga Dussehra, in May or June, celebrates the descent of Ganga to earth. Devotees bathe in the river, and the ghats are decorated for special aartis. It is a joyful, river-centred festival, though be prepared for intense summer heat. In 2027 it is expected around **13 June 2027** (verify).

Chhath

Chhath is a festival dedicated to the sun god Surya and to Chhathi Maiya, especially important to people from Bihar and eastern Uttar Pradesh. A few days after Diwali, devotees, mostly women, fast rigorously, often without even water, and stand in the river at sunset and again at sunrise to offer prayers and offerings of fruit and sweets in bamboo baskets. The ghats fill with families, lamps, sugarcane and songs. It is one of the most beautiful and moving sights of the year. In 2026, the main evening offering falls around **15 November** and the dawn offering on **16 November** (verify).

Nag Nathaiya

Nag Nathaiya is a theatrical re-enactment, performed at Tulsi Ghat, of the story of the young **Krishna** subduing the serpent **Kaliya**, who had poisoned the Yamuna river. A boy playing Krishna leaps into the Ganga, now standing in for the Yamuna, and emerges standing on the hood of a

model serpent, playing his flute. Thousands gather on the ghats and in boats to watch, and the cry of the crowd when Krishna appears is unforgettable. The performance is part of the city's long tradition of **Krishna Lila** and takes place during the month of Kartik, a few days after Diwali, on the fourth day of the bright fortnight (verify the date each year locally).

Other celebrations

- **Ramlila at Ramnagar**, across the river, is a month-long open-air performance of the Ramayana in autumn, patronised for generations by the royal family of Banaras, and recognised as one of the great traditions of Indian theatre.
- **Navratri and Durga Puja** in autumn, with large decorated pandals honouring the goddess, especially in the Bengali neighbourhoods.
- **Shravan**, the monsoon month dedicated to Shiva, when saffron-clad pilgrims called **kanwariyas** carry Ganga water to temples, and Mondays at Kashi Vishwanath are extremely crowded.
- **Buddha Purnima** at Sarnath, usually in May, honouring the Buddha's birth, enlightenment and passing.



CHAPTER 10

Music, Scholarship and the Arts

A city that sings

For many Indians, Banaras is as much a city of music as of temples. Its devotion has always been expressed in sound: bells, chants, hymns, and some of the finest classical music in the world.

The city is home to the **Banaras gharana**, a stylistic lineage of Hindustani classical music. Banaras is especially renowned for the **tabla**, with a powerful, resonant style, and for vocal forms such as **thumri**, **dadra**, **chaiti** and **kajri**, lighter classical and semi-classical songs often expressing love, longing and the changing seasons. The great singers of Banaras, including **Girija Devi**, known as the "Queen of Thumri," and **Siddheshwari Devi**, carried this tradition to concert stages across the world.

Bismillah Khan and the shehnai

No musician is more closely identified with Varanasi than **Ustad Bismillah Khan** (1916–2006). He made the **shehnai**, a double-reed wind instrument traditionally played at weddings and temple ceremonies, into a concert instrument of the highest rank. He played at the Red Fort in Delhi on the eve of India's independence in 1947 and was awarded the **Bharat Ratna**, India's highest civilian honour, in 2001.

Bismillah Khan was a devout Muslim who practised for years on the ghats and in the temples of Kashi, and he spoke of his deep love for the city, the Ganga and Kashi Vishwanath. He famously declined offers to settle abroad because he could not imagine living away from Banaras and its river. For many people, his life embodies the shared, plural culture of the city.

Ravi Shankar's city

Pandit Ravi Shankar (1920–2012), the sitar maestro who introduced Indian classical music to Western audiences, collaborated with George Harrison of the Beatles, and performed at Monterey and Woodstock, was born in Varanasi. Though his career took him around the world, the city remained part of his story, and some of the Westerners who came to Varanasi in the 1960s and 70s came partly because of the music he had made famous.

LOCAL TIP

Look out for small concerts and music evenings during your stay, especially in winter. Guesthouses, cultural centres and music schools near Assi often host performances, and several music festivals, including the Sankat Mochan Sangeet Samaroh in spring and the Dhrupad Mela at Tulsi Ghat, draw leading artists.

Kabir and Tulsidas: two poets, one city

Two poets dominate the spiritual literature of Varanasi.

Kabir (fifteenth century) was a weaver, raised in a Muslim weaving family, whose poems mocked the rituals and hypocrisy of both Hindus and Muslims and pointed instead to a formless divine found within the heart. His short couplets, called **dohas**, are still quoted by ordinary people every day across North India. Tradition associates him with the area of **Kabir Chaura** in Varanasi and the pond at **Lahartara**. Legend says that, at his death, Hindus and Muslims both claimed his body; when the shroud was lifted, only flowers were found, which each community took away.

Tulsidas (sixteenth century) took the opposite path to the same destination: total devotion to Rama. His *Ramcharitmanas* made the story of the Ramayana available to ordinary people in their own language, and it remains one of the most widely read and recited religious texts in India. You will hear verses from it sung in homes, temples and on the ghats.

A city of learning

Kashi has been a centre of learning for thousands of years. Scholars came here to study Sanskrit, philosophy, grammar, logic, astronomy, medicine and the Vedas, and to debate with other scholars. The saying went that a scholar's reputation was not established until it had been tested in Kashi.

That tradition continues. **Sampurnanand Sanskrit University**, which grew out of a Sanskrit college founded in 1791, is one of the oldest institutions of its kind. Traditional schools for Vedic recitation, called **pathshalas**, still operate in the lanes, where boys in white learn to chant Vedic texts with precise intonation, exactly as their teachers did before them.

Banaras Hindu University (BHU), founded in 1916 by **Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya**, is one of the largest residential universities in Asia, with a vast green campus in the south of the city. It combines modern science and engineering with Indian music, fine arts, Ayurveda and Sanskrit studies.

Banarasi silk: a living craft

The **Banarasi sari** is among the most treasured garments in India, worn by brides across the country. These saris are woven in fine silk with intricate patterns of gold and silver thread, called **zari**, featuring motifs of flowers, vines, birds and Mughal-inspired designs. Banarasi saris and brocades have received Geographical Indication status, recognising their unique origin.

The weaving is done largely by families in neighbourhoods such as **Madanpura** and areas around the city, many of them from Muslim weaving communities, on handlooms and powerlooms. A complex handwoven sari can take weeks or even months to complete. Listen as you walk through these neighbourhoods and you may hear the rhythmic clack of the looms from open doorways.

LOCAL TIP

Be wary of "free silk factory tours" offered by rickshaw drivers or touts. These usually end in a high-pressure showroom where the driver earns a commission on everything you buy. If you want to buy a genuine Banarasi sari, take your time, compare shops, and ask about the Silk Mark label, which certifies pure silk.



CHAPTER 11

Yoga, Meditation and Spiritual Practice

Why seekers come to Kashi

For centuries, Kashi has drawn renunciates, philosophers, yogis and seekers of every kind. The city is associated with great teachers of the Vedanta tradition, and with countless lesser-known sadhus, scholars and practitioners. Today, you will find yoga classes, meditation groups, Sanskrit courses, philosophy talks and ashrams across the city, especially around Assi and the southern ghats.

Varanasi is not a "yoga resort" in the polished sense. Its practice is rougher, more rooted, and more woven into daily life. That is precisely its value.

Finding an authentic teacher

Most yoga teachers in Varanasi are sincere people offering honest classes at fair prices. But as in any spiritual centre that attracts foreigners, there are also people who use the language of spirituality to exploit visitors. A few signs of a trustworthy teacher:

- **They are happy to tell you where and with whom they studied**, and you can verify this.
- **Their prices are clear and stated upfront**, and broadly in line with what other teachers charge.
- **Other students, including locals, attend their classes.**
- **They respect your boundaries**, including physical ones, and ask before making any hands-on adjustment.
- **They do not ask you to give up your judgement.**

Red flags of fake gurus

Walk away from anyone who:

- **Approaches you on the street or ghat** to offer spiritual teaching, initiation or a special blessing.
- **Claims miraculous powers**, or claims to be able to remove "bad karma" or curses for a fee.
- **Asks for large sums of money**, especially for "special" initiations, rituals or secret teachings.
- **Insists on private, one-on-one sessions** in isolated places, or on physical contact that makes you uncomfortable.
- **Offers you drugs**, including bhang or charas, as part of "spiritual practice."
- **Discourages you from contacting family or friends**, or tells you that doubt is a spiritual failing.
- **Tells you that you have been "chosen"** or that your meeting was destined.

Genuine teachers in the Indian tradition have always emphasised that the student must test the teacher. Trust your instincts.

Ashram etiquette

If you stay in or visit an ashram:

- **Follow the house rules** about meals, silence, wake-up times and dress without complaint.
- **Dress modestly** in loose clothing that covers shoulders and knees.
- **Avoid alcohol, meat, and often eggs, onion and garlic** on the premises. Many ashrams follow a strictly vegetarian or satvik diet.
- **Offer to help** with chores if others do. Service, called **seva**, is part of the practice.
- **Offer a donation** at the end of your stay if no fixed fee is charged. Ask quietly what is customary.
- **Do not photograph** teachers or other residents without permission.

Silent sunrise practice on the ghats

You do not need a teacher or a class to practise in Varanasi. One of the most powerful things you can do is simply this:

1. **Rise before dawn** and walk down to a quiet ghat. Kedar, Tulsi, or the steps just north or south of Assi are good choices.
2. **Find a step a little away from others.** Sit facing the river and the eastern sky.
3. **Begin with ten minutes of breath awareness.** Simply notice the breath moving in and out.
4. **Open your eyes and watch the light change** for another ten minutes, without reaching for your phone.

5. **If you wish, chant or silently repeat** a word or mantra that is meaningful to you, such as "Om."
6. **Close by bowing** toward the river, or simply placing your palms together for a moment.

Do this every morning of your stay and you will find that Varanasi changes around you, or perhaps that you change within it.

LOCAL TIP

If you practise asana on the ghats, choose a quiet spot, wear modest clothing, and avoid poses that point your feet toward temples or people at prayer. Some locals may watch with curiosity. A smile goes a long way.

A three-day spiritual itinerary

Day 1: The river

- Dawn: Silent practice on the ghats, then Subah-e-Banaras at Assi Ghat.
- Morning: Sunrise rowing boat from Assi to Manikarnika and back, using the meditation in Chapter 5.
- Afternoon: Rest. Read about the Ganga and the story of Bhagiratha.
- Evening: Ganga Aarti at Dashashwamedh from the steps. Offer a diya.

Day 2: Shiva's city

- Early morning: Darshan at Kashi Vishwanath (no phone, bring passport), then Annapurna.
- Late morning: Kal Bhairav, to ask the Kotwal's permission for your stay.
- Afternoon: Rest, then a slow walk north to Manikarnika. Sit quietly at a distance for half an hour. No camera.

- Evening: A music performance if you can find one, or a quiet aarti at Assi.

Day 3: The Buddha and the poets

- Morning: Sarnath, with walking meditation around the Dhamek Stupa (avoid the museum on Fridays).
- Afternoon: Sankat Mochan, Durga temple and Tulsi Manas Mandir; or the calm of the New Vishwanath temple at BHU.
- Evening: A final sunset boat, or simply sit at Kedar Ghat and say goodbye to the river.



CHAPTER 12

Food as Prasad: The Culture of Taste

Eating in a sacred city

In Kashi, food is never just food. It is offered to the gods before it is eaten, shared as prasad, and given freely to pilgrims and the poor. The goddess Annapurna, we have seen, is believed to ensure that no one in Kashi sleeps hungry. Eating well here is part of the experience of the city.

Kachori-sabzi and jalebi

A classic Banarasi breakfast is **kachori-sabzi**: puffed, fried bread stuffed with spiced lentils, served with a spicy potato curry, followed by hot **jalebi**, coils of fried batter soaked in syrup. It is heavy, hot and wonderful. Look for busy stalls in the early morning where locals are eating and the oil is fresh.

Malaiyo: the winter dew-sweet

Malaiyo (also called *makhan malaiyo*) is a seasonal sweet available only in the cold months, roughly November to February. Milk is boiled, then left out overnight in the cold winter air, traditionally to catch the morning dew, and churned in the morning into a light, airy froth flavoured with saffron, cardamom and pistachio. It melts the moment it touches your tongue. If you are in Varanasi in winter, do not leave without trying it, early in the morning, before it sells out.

Lassi in a kulhad

Lassi is a thick, sweet yogurt drink, often topped with a layer of cream (**malai**) and sometimes nuts or fruit. In Varanasi it is served in a **kulhad**, an unglazed clay cup that gives a faint earthy taste and is thrown away after use. The kulhad is a beautiful example of traditional sustainability: it simply returns to the earth.

Banarasi paan

Paan is a preparation of betel leaf wrapped around a filling, chewed after meals as a digestive and mouth-freshener. The **Banarasi paan** is famous across India. A typical paan includes:

- **Betel leaf**, the wrapper.
- **Kattha**, a red-brown paste from acacia wood, and **chuna**, slaked lime.
- **Supari**, areca nut, which is a stimulant.
- Sweet additions such as **gulkand** (rose-petal jam), fennel, coconut and cardamom.

Meetha paan, sweet paan, contains no tobacco and is the best choice for visitors. Ask for it "without tobacco" and, if you prefer, "without supari." Do not swallow the whole thing at once; chew slowly. Be aware

that areca nut and tobacco are linked to serious health risks with regular use.

Thandai and bhang

Thandai is a cooling milk drink made with almonds, fennel, cardamom, rose, pepper and saffron, especially popular at Holi and Mahashivratri. It is delicious and harmless in its plain form. But some thandai, and some lassis, are prepared with **bhang**, a cannabis preparation associated with Shiva and sold in licensed government shops. Bhang can be extremely strong, its effects can take hours to start and can last much longer, and visitors regularly have frightening experiences with it. If you are offered a "special" lassi or thandai, ask clearly whether it contains bhang, and if you are not sure, decline.

Satvik food

Many temples, ashrams and devout households in Varanasi follow a **satvik** diet. In yogic thought, food has qualities that affect the mind: **satvik** (pure, calm), **rajasic** (stimulating) and **tamasic** (dulling). Satvik food is vegetarian, fresh and lightly spiced, and usually avoids onion, garlic, alcohol and meat. Much of the old city around the temples is strictly vegetarian.

Food-safety tips

- **Eat where locals eat**, and where food is cooked fresh and hot in front of you.
- **Drink only sealed bottled water** or filtered water you trust. Avoid ice unless you know its source.
- **Peel your fruit**, or eat only cooked food in your first few days.
- **Be cautious with uncooked chutneys and raw salads** from street stalls.

- **Introduce spicy and fried food gradually.**
- **Carry oral rehydration salts**, just in case.

LOCAL TIP

Try **tamatar chaat**, a uniquely Banarasi street snack of spiced tomato cooked with potato and topped with crunchy bits, and **baati chokha**, roasted wheat dumplings with smoky mashed vegetables. Both are cooked hot, which also makes them a safer choice.



CHAPTER 13

The Respect Guide

Most of the courtesies that matter in Varanasi are simple. Here they are in one place.

Dress

- **Cover shoulders and knees**, for everyone, especially at temples, ghats and ashrams. Loose cotton or linen is ideal in the heat.
- **Women** will feel more comfortable in loose trousers or long skirts and a top that covers the shoulders, with a light scarf or dupatta for temples. Tight or revealing clothing attracts unwanted attention.
- **Men** should avoid going shirtless, except when bathing.

Shoes and feet

- **Remove shoes** before temples, homes, ashrams and the lower bathing platforms.
- **Do not point your feet** at people, deities, shrines or the river. Tuck them sideways when you sit.
- **If you accidentally touch someone with your foot**, touch your hand to their arm and then to your own forehead or chest, a common gesture of apology.

The right hand

The left hand is traditionally associated with cleaning oneself. **Use your right hand** to eat, to give and receive money, prasad and gifts, and to touch anything sacred. Giving with both hands is extra respectful.

Cows

Cows are sacred in Hinduism and wander freely through Varanasi. **Do not hit, push or provoke them.** Give them space in narrow lanes, never stand directly behind them, and watch your step. Bulls, especially, deserve a wide berth.

Photography

- **Never photograph cremations.**
- **Ask before photographing people**, especially women, the elderly, bathers and people at prayer.
- **No photography inside temple sanctums** unless clearly permitted.
- **No drones** without official permission.

Sadhus: real and costume

You will meet many **sadhus**, holy men who have renounced worldly life, with ash-covered bodies, matted hair and saffron robes. Some are genuine renunciates of long standing. Others dress the part mainly to pose for tourist photographs.

- **Ask before photographing any sadhu.** A small offering of ₹20 to ₹100 is customary if they agree.
- **Do not accept or share drugs** with sadhus, however friendly.
- **Treat genuine renunciates with respect**, and do not mock anyone's appearance.
- **Women should be cautious** about accepting invitations to private spaces.

Public affection and behaviour

- **Keep public affection discreet.** Holding hands is fine; kissing in public is not appropriate here.
- **Keep your voice low** at temples, ghats at dawn and near cremation grounds.
- **Avoid alcohol** in public and near religious sites. Parts of the old city around temples restrict the sale of alcohol and meat.

LOCAL TIP

When in doubt, watch what local people around you are doing and follow their lead. And if you make a mistake, a sincere "sorry" with folded hands is almost always met with a smile.



A Closing Reflection

I have tried in these pages to share what Kashi means to the people who love it. But I know that no book can hold this city.

When I was a boy, the old men on the ghats used to say that you do not come to Kashi; Kashi calls you. I did not understand it then. I thought they were simply proud of their city. Now, after years of watching travellers arrive at the river, I think I understand. Some people come for a day and leave unchanged. Others come and something shifts in them, a question opens up, a grief is eased, a long-held fear of death loosens a little. They return home carrying something they cannot name.

I hope that, whatever brought you here, you will give the city time. Sit on the steps. Watch the light. Let the bells ring through you. Talk to the boatmen and the chai sellers and the old women at dawn. Be patient with the noise, firm with the touts, and gentle with yourself.

And when you leave, carry a little of Kashi's light with you.

Companions for your journey

This book is about meaning. If you also want the practical side of the city, our companion book, the **Varanasi Insider Guide**, covers prices, scams and scripts to deal with them, transport, food safety and detailed itineraries. You can find it at kashigo.in/guide.

If you would like to experience the river with someone who knows it, KashiGo is preparing sunrise and Ganga Aarti boat experiences at fixed, fair prices with trusted local boatmen. Join the free list at kashigo.in to hear when they open.

Har Har Mahadev. Ganga Maiya ki jai.

— Vaibhav Upadhyay, Varanasi



Glossary

Aarti — Worship by circling a lamp before a deity.

Agni — The god of fire; fire as a sacred element and messenger to the gods.

Akash deep — "Sky lamp"; lamps hung on tall poles during Kartik for the ancestors.

Akhara — A traditional wrestling ground; also an order of ascetics.

Annapurna — Goddess of food and nourishment, a form of Parvati.

Ashram — A spiritual community or retreat.

Atman — The individual soul or self.

Bhang — A preparation of cannabis, traditionally associated with Shiva.

Chamar — A yak-tail whisk used in worship as a royal honour.

Dakshina — A voluntary offering to a priest or teacher.

Darshan — Seeing, and being seen by, the divine.

Deep / Diya — An oil lamp; in Varanasi, often a leaf-boat with a flame floated on the river.

Dharma — Duty, righteousness, cosmic order; in Buddhism, the Buddha's teaching.

Dhoop — Incense.

Dom — The community that traditionally tends the cremation grounds.

Gali — A narrow lane of the old city.

Ganga snan — Ritual bathing in the Ganga.

Gangajal — Water of the Ganga, kept for ritual use.

Gharana — A lineage or school of classical music.

Ghat — Stone steps leading down to a river.

Janeu — The sacred thread worn across the body.

Jyotirlinga — One of twelve most sacred shrines of Shiva as a pillar of light.

Kalava / Mauli — Red-and-yellow protective thread tied on the wrist.

Karma — Action and its consequences, shaping future births.

Kartik — A holy lunar month, roughly October to November.

Kotwal — Chief of police; Kal Bhairav's title as guardian of Kashi.

Kulhad — An unglazed, disposable clay cup.

Kund — A sacred pool or tank.

Lingam — The aniconic symbol of Shiva.

Mallah — The traditional boatmen community.

Mantra — A sacred sound, word or verse.

Moksha — Liberation from the cycle of rebirth.

Mundan — Ritual head-shaving.

Panda — A pilgrim priest at a sacred site.

Pind daan — Offering of rice balls for the ancestors.

Pradakshina — Walking clockwise around something sacred.

Prasad — Food offered to a deity and shared as blessing.

Puja — Worship.

Purnima — The full-moon day.

Sadhu — A renunciate holy man.

Samsara — The cycle of birth, death and rebirth.

Sangha — The Buddhist community.

Satvik — Pure, calming; also a diet free of meat, onion and garlic.

Seva — Selfless service.

Shankh — The conch shell.

Shraddha — Rites honouring ancestors.

Stupa — A Buddhist dome-shaped monument.

Taraka mantra — The "crossing" mantra Shiva is believed to whisper to the dying in Kashi.

Tilak — A sacred mark on the forehead.

Tirthankara — In Jainism, one of the twenty-four great teachers.

Uttaravahini — North-flowing; a sacred river turning north.



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A SMALL FAVOUR

If this book helped you, a short honest review on the store where you bought it helps other travellers find it — and means the world to a small Varanasi business. Thank you, and har har Mahadev.